

漢字

KANJIDOKU

Sudoku that leaves you with a word

5 puzzles from the book

There are 100 in it.



Nine characters, not nine numbers

Kanjidoku is sudoku. If you have done a sudoku you already know the rule, and it does not change: every row, every column and every outlined box must contain each character exactly once.

The only difference is that the nine symbols are kanji instead of the digits 1 to 9. You do not need to know what they mean to solve the grid. A symbol is a symbol. But every puzzle prints its characters in a numbered key at the top of the page, with readings and meanings, and by the time you have written 火 nine times in nine different places you will find you know it.

That is the whole idea. Nobody learns a character by looking at it once. You learn it by needing it.

IF THE CHARACTERS LOOK LIKE SOUP

They will, at first, and there is a legitimate shortcut. The key numbers every character from 1 to 9. Solve the grid in pencil using the numbers, then go back and write the characters in. You get the puzzle and the writing practice, in that order, and after three or four grids most people stop needing the numbers.

THE TWO TECHNIQUES YOU NEED

The last empty seat

Look at a single cell. Cross off every character that already appears in its row, its column and its box. If exactly one character survives, it goes there.

The only home left

Look at a single row, column or box and pick one character. Cross off every cell in that unit where the character cannot go. If exactly one cell survives, the character goes there.

No puzzle in this book needs anything harder than those two. If you find yourself wanting to guess, there is a move you have not spotted yet.

HOW TO PLAY

The word at the end

Two or three cells in every grid are shaded and carry a small number. They are always empty at the start, so you cannot read the word without solving the puzzle first.

When the grid is full, read those cells in numbered order. You will have a real Japanese word, built out of characters you have just spent twenty minutes with. Write it into the boxes at the foot of the page with its reading and meaning; the answer is at the back alongside the solved grid.

WORKED EXAMPLE

学	本	語	日
語	日	学	本 ^②
^① 日	語	本	学
本	学	日	語 ^③

This grid is already solved.

Cells 1, 2 and 3 are shaded. Read them in that order:

日本語 ^{nihongo} にほんご
Japanese (language)

All three characters were in the key at the top of the page all along, so you already have the reading and the meaning.

HOW THIS SAMPLE IS ORDERED

The grids grow one step at a time. Four by four, then five, six, seven, eight and nine. Each size needs exactly that many characters, which is why the sets can stay tight: seven characters is the seven days of the week, five is the five position words.

Two of them are jigsaws. Boxes have to be rectangles, so the grid size has to divide: four is two by two, nine is three by three. Five and seven are prime and cannot be cut into rectangles at all, so those two grids use irregular regions instead. Nothing else changes: follow the heavy outline instead of counting squares.

Easier characters first. The N5 grids come before the N4 grids, and several later sets are earlier sets with more characters added, so you often start a big grid already knowing most of it.

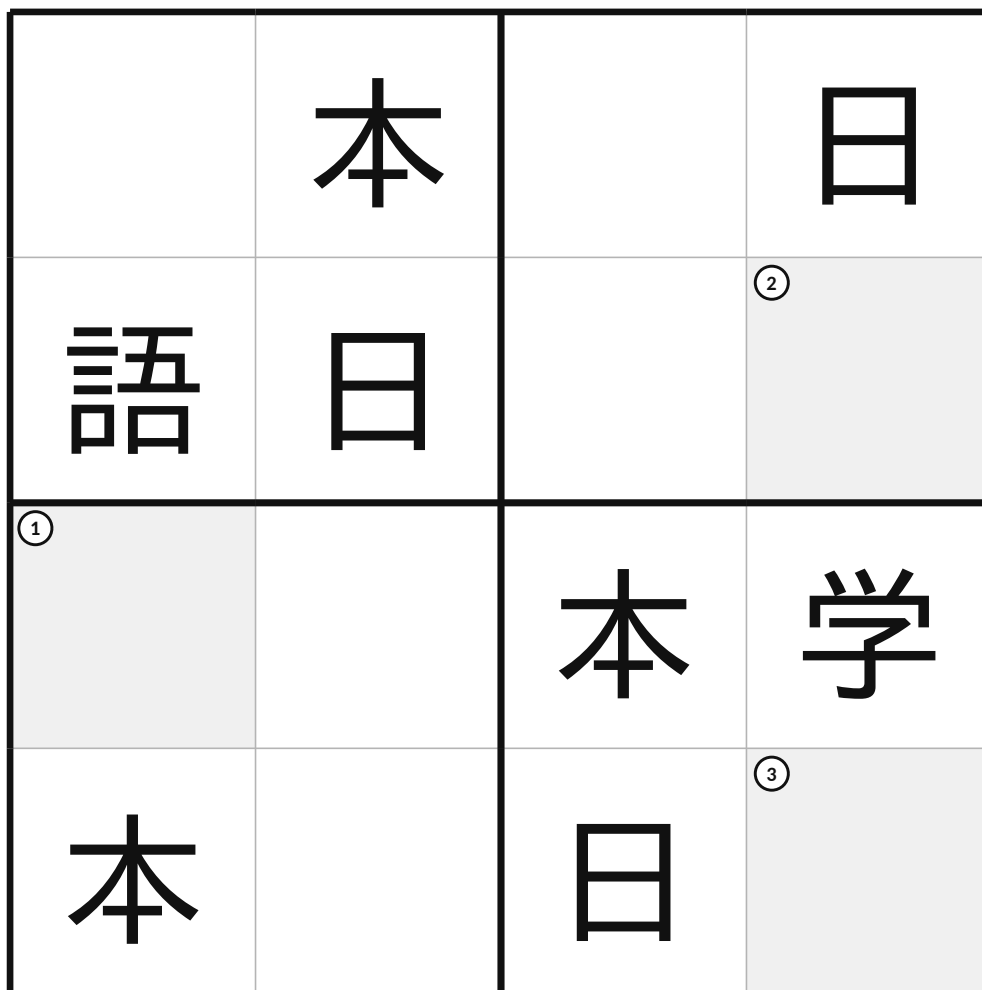
The language itself

① 日 hi ka nichi jitsu
ひ・か / ニチ・ジツ
sun; day

② 本 moto hon
もと / ホン
book; origin

③ 語 kata ru go
かた(る) / ゴ
language; to tell

④ 学 mana bu gaku
まな(ぶ) / ガク
study; learning



THE HIDDEN WORD

1	2	3
---	---	---

reading

meaning

At school

① 学 mana bu gaku
まな(ぶ) / ガク
study; learning

② 校 kō
コウ
school

③ 生 life; student
i kiru u mareru sei
い(きる)・う(まれる) / セイ

④ 先 saki sen
さき / セン
ahead; previous

⑤ 本 moto hon
もと / ホン
book; origin

⑥ 大 big
ō kii dai tai
おお(きい) / ダイ・タイ

②			大	本	先
			学		生
	大	校		先	
	生		本	大	
学		本			
生	先	大		①	

THE HIDDEN WORD

1	2
---	---

reading _____
meaning _____

Which way

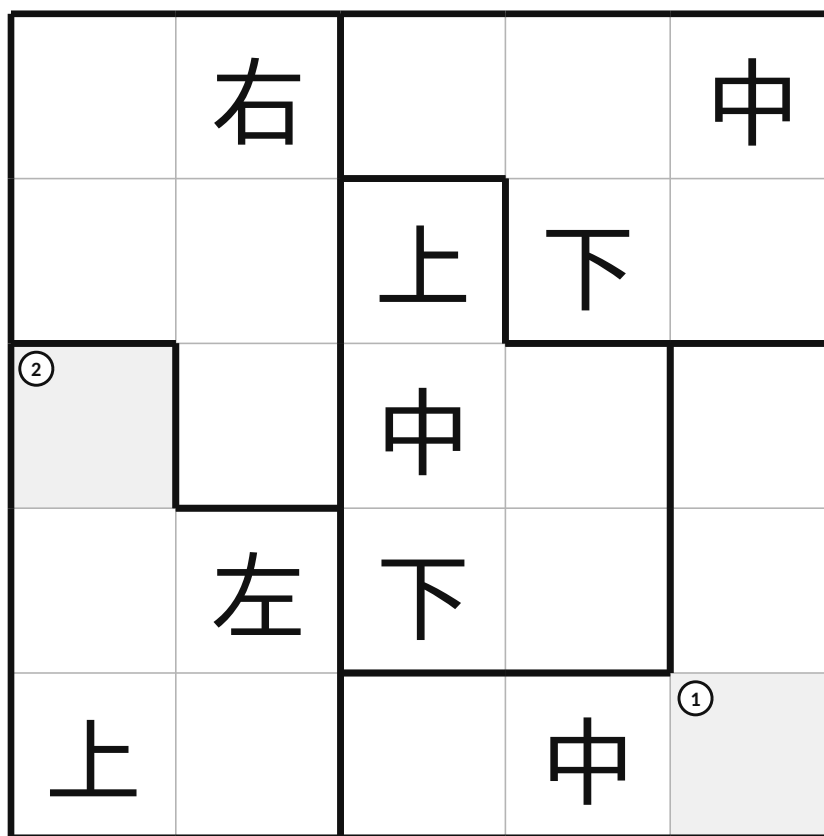
① 上 ^{ue} / ^{jō}
うゑ / ジョウ
above; up

② 下 ^{shita} / ^{ka ge}
した / カ・ゲ
below; down

③ 左 ^{hidari} / ^{sa}
ひだり / サ
left

④ 右 ^{migi} / ^{u yū}
みぎ / ウ・ユウ
right

⑤ 中 ^{naka} / ^{chū}
なか / チュウ
middle; inside



THE HIDDEN WORD

1	2

reading _____
meaning _____

Morning to night

- ① 春 haru shun
はる / シュン
springtime
- ② 夏 natsu ka ga
なつ / カ・ガ
summer
- ③ 秋 aki shū
あき / シュウ
autumn
- ④ 冬 fuyu tō
ふゆ / トウ
winter
- ⑤ 朝 asa chō
あさ / チョウ
morning; dynasty
- ⑥ 昼 hiru chū
ひる / チュウ
daytime; noon
- ⑦ 夜 yo ya
よ / ヤ
night; evening
- ⑧ 午 uma go
うま / ゴ
noon
- ⑨ 前 mae zen
まえ / ゼン
front; before

		春	朝	秋				午
秋	朝					冬	春	①
			午				前	朝
	前				夜			冬
				冬				
午			昼				夜	
春	昼				午			
②	夏	秋					朝	前
冬				夏	秋	春		

THE HIDDEN WORD

1	2
---	---

reading _____

meaning _____

The exam

① 質 tachi shitsu shichi
たち / シツ・シチ
substance; quality

② 問 tō mon
と(う) / モン
question; ask

③ 試 kokoro miru shi
こころ(みる) / シ
test; try

④ 験 akashi ken gen
あかし / ケン・ゲン
test; verification

⑤ 研 to gu ken
と(ぐ) / ケン
polish; study

⑥ 究 research; study
kiwa meru kyū ku
きわ(める) / キュウ・ク

⑦ 勉 tsuto meru ben
つと(める) / ベン
exertion; endeavour

⑧ 強 strong
tsuyo i kyō gō
つよ(い) / キョウ・ゴウ

⑨ 学 mana bu gaku
まな(ぶ) / ガク
study; learning

勉					強	②		
						試	研	
験	研				試			質
質	験	問	強				究	
		勉		問		強		
	学				究	問	験	勉
研			試				勉	験
	問	質						
①			学					問

THE HIDDEN WORD

1	2
---	---

reading _____
meaning _____

Solutions

Characters in grey are the ones you had to work out; black ones were given. The note under each word is the reason that word was worth hiding.

学	本	語	日
語	日	学	本 ^②
^① 日	語	本	学
本	学	日	語 ^③

3. THE LANGUAGE ITSELF

日本語 ^{nihongo} にほんご
Japanese (language)

日本 (にほん, nihon) is 'sun origin', the country the sun comes from. Add 語 and you have its language. 語 turns any country into a language: 英語 (えいご, eigo) English, 中国語 (ちゅうごくご, chūgokugo) Chinese.

^② 校	学	生	大	本	先
大	本	先	学	校	生
本	大	校	生	先	学
先	生	学	本	大	校
学	校	本	先	生	大
生	先	大	校	^① 学	本

8. AT SCHOOL

学校 ^{gakkō} がっこう
school

An unusually generous set. Besides 学校 you can also build 先生 (せんせい, sensei) (teacher), 学生 (がくせい, gakusei) (student) and 大学 (だいがく, daigaku) (university), four real words from six characters.

下	右	左	上	中
左	中	上	下	右
^② 右	上	中	左	下
中	左	下	右	上
上	下	右	中	^① 左

13. WHICH WAY

左右 ^{sayū} さゆう
left and right; right and left

Five is a prime number, so a five-by-five grid cannot be cut into rectangular boxes at all, hence the irregular regions. The rule has not changed. 左右 is also a verb: 左右する (さゆうする, sayūsuru) means to influence something.

前	冬	春	朝	秋	昼	夜	夏	午
秋	朝	午	夏	夜	前	冬	春	① 昼
夏	夜	昼	午	春	冬	秋	前	朝
朝	前	夏	春	午	夜	昼	秋	冬
昼	春	夜	秋	冬	朝	前	午	夏
午	秋	冬	昼	前	夏	朝	夜	春
春	昼	前	夜	朝	午	夏	冬	秋
② 夜	夏	秋	冬	昼	春	午	朝	前
冬	午	朝	前	夏	秋	春	昼	夜

55. MORNING TO NIGHT

昼夜 ^{chūya} ちゅうや
day and night

昼夜 is day-and-night, meaning around the clock.
昼夜を問わず (ちゅうやをとわず, chūya o towazu) means regardless of the hour.

勉	質	試	問	研	強	② 験	学	究
問	究	学	勉	験	質	試	研	強
験	研	強	究	学	試	勉	問	質
質	験	問	強	勉	学	研	究	試
究	試	勉	研	問	験	強	質	学
強	学	研	質	試	究	問	験	勉
研	強	究	試	質	問	学	勉	験
学	問	質	験	強	勉	究	試	研
① 試	勉	験	学	究	研	質	強	問

94. THE EXAM

試験 ^{shiken} しけん
examination; exam

試験 is the exam, and it is what the T in JLPT stands for:
日本語能力試験 (にほんごのうりよくしけん, nihongonōryokushiken), the Japanese Language Proficiency Test.

Writing it out

Solving teaches you to recognise a character. Writing teaches you to remember it. Trace the grey model, then fill the rest of the row from memory.

Two rules of stroke order cover most characters: **top before bottom**, and **left before right**. Where they conflict, a horizontal stroke usually comes before the vertical one crossing it. 十 is drawn across, then down. Stroke order is not pedantry. It is what keeps a character legible when you write it quickly, and it is how a paper dictionary is indexed.

The dotted cross is there so you can judge proportion. Most of a character's legibility lives in how it sits in the square rather than in the strokes themselves.

日				sun hi ひ	本				book moto もと
語				language kataru かた (る)	学				study manabu まな (ぶ)
校				school kō コウ	生				life ikiru い (きる)
先				ahead saki さき	大				big ōkii おお (きい)
上				above ue うえ	下				below shita した
左				left hidari ひだり	右				right migi みぎ
中				middle naka なか	春				springtime haru はる
夏				summer natsu なつ	秋				autumn aki あき
冬				winter fuyu ふゆ	朝				morning asa あさ

There are ninety-five more

Volume One holds **100 puzzles** and every character of N5 and N4 - 246 of them - each with its readings and meaning printed on the page you meet it.

Full solutions. Every grid worked out, with the hidden word, its reading and a note on where the word turns up in real Japanese.

A complete index. All 246 characters, with every puzzle each one appears in, for when one turns up three grids later and you cannot place it.

Writing practice. Squares to write in for every character in the book, with a grey model to trace and the stroke-order rules explained.

THE SERIES

Kanjidoku N3. About 370 more characters, and the level where Japanese stops being survival vocabulary and starts being a newspaper headline.

Kanjidoku N2. Another 380 or so. Longer compounds, more abstract words, and grids that hide four-character phrases.

Kanjidoku N1. Everything left. Nobody finishes N1 in a hurry.

PLEASE SHARE THIS

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KANJIDOKU.NET for the rest of the series, and the other samplers



MIND QUESTS